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NOTHING STAYS HIDDEN

EVERY SECRET FINDS
ITS WAY TO THE LIGHT

SONIA BENJOYE

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Every Secret Finds Its Way to the Light

By Sonia Benjoye

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Dedication

For the day every shadow learns it can't last.

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Chapter One

The Witness

"I saw it happen. I said nothing."

It was a Thursday afternoon. Not that the day matters, but I remember because the street was busier than usual.

The noise came first. Not a crash. Not a scream. Just a sharp, short sound, like someone hitting metal with their hand. People turned, but not all at once. Some didn't notice at all.

I saw it. I saw exactly what happened. And I chose to look away.

I told myself it wasn't my business. That someone else would step in. That the person would be fine.

They weren't.

I kept walking. My pace didn't change. I didn't run. I didn't stop. I just blended into the crowd and hoped no one noticed me.

I felt the weight of it immediately. It sat in my stomach. Not panic, not guilt. Just weight.

At the next corner, I almost turned back. I could still hear voices, louder now. The kind of noise that builds when people gather around something. But I didn't turn.

When I got home, I left my shoes by the door like I always do. I washed my hands twice. I sat on the couch and turned on the television.

The news was on, but it wasn't there yet. I kept flipping through channels, half listening, half waiting for it.

It came an hour later. Same street. Same spot. Same time.

They showed the body covered with a sheet. They didn't show the face, but they didn't have to. I already knew.

I leaned back and closed my eyes.

I could have said something.

I could have shouted.

I could have stepped in.

But I didn't.

And now it's mine to carry.

The next day, two officers came to my door.

They didn't say how they found me. They didn't need to. The street had cameras. People had phones. I had walked past them.

One of them asked if I saw anything unusual. I told him no. He wrote something down.

The other one just stared at me. Not in an angry way. More like he was trying to decide if I was worth pressing harder.

They thanked me and left.

For the rest of the day, I felt the knock at my door in my chest. Every sound outside made me look up.

By the weekend, the story was everywhere. It wasn't just a death anymore. They were calling it suspicious.

I avoided the news, but it found me anyway. In the grocery store, in the office, on my phone. People kept talking about it like they knew the whole thing.

No one did.

I started seeing the same brown leather shoe in my head every time someone mentioned it.

A week later, they came back. This time, they didn't just knock. They had a warrant. They went through my apartment. They took my phone, my laptop, even the receipts on my kitchen counter.

I sat in a chair while they worked. I didn't ask questions.

They left with boxes of my things. One of them told me they'd be in touch.

When the door closed, I realized I'd been holding my breath for hours.

It didn't matter that I hadn't touched the body. It didn't matter that I hadn't spoken a word to anyone about it. I was part of it now.

And there was no way out.

Two days later, they called me in. The station was colder than I expected. The walls were beige, the kind that look like they've been the same color for twenty years.

They put me in a room with a table, two chairs, and a camera in the corner. No window. Just a clock that ticked loud enough to notice.

A man in a suit came in first. He sat across from me, opened a folder, and didn't look up for almost a minute. Then he asked if I wanted water. I said no.

He started with basic questions. My name. My address. Where I was on that Thursday. I told him I was on that street walking home.

Then he asked if I saw anything. I said no.

He didn't write that down. He just looked at me for a few seconds, then leaned back.

Another officer came in. She brought a small recorder, pressed a button, and said the time and date out loud. They asked the same questions again, this time recording my answers.

Halfway through, the man in the suit asked about the brown leather shoe.

My mouth went dry. I didn't ask how he knew. I didn't tell him I'd been thinking about that shoe every day. I just said I didn't notice it.

He kept his eyes on me the whole time I answered.

When they let me leave, I felt lighter for a moment. Then I realized the feeling wasn't relief. It was because I thought maybe they believed me. But I knew they didn't.

That night, I barely slept. Every sound in the hallway made me think they were coming back.

A week went by. Then another. I thought maybe it was over.

Until the news broke again.

They'd found new evidence. Witness statements. A security camera angle no one had seen before.

And there I was.

It wasn't close. It wasn't clear. But it was me. My coat. My bag. My head turning toward the sound.

The anchor on the news said they were looking to speak with anyone who might have been in that area at the time.

My phone started ringing before the segment ended.

I didn't answer the phone. Not the first call, not the fifth. It kept ringing. Different numbers. Unknown, private, blocked.

By the afternoon, someone knocked on my door. I froze where I was standing. The knock wasn't loud, but it was steady. Whoever it was knew I was inside.

I stayed still. After a while, they left.

That night, there was an envelope under my door. No name on the front. Inside, a single sheet of paper.

It said, **We need to talk about what you saw.**

No number. No instructions.

I read it twice, then burned it in the kitchen sink.

The next day, I saw her. Standing across the street, leaning on a wall like she was waiting for someone. Short hair, heavy jacket, sunglasses even though it was cloudy. She didn't look at me directly, but she didn't have to.

I knew she was there for me.

When I turned the corner, my phone buzzed in my pocket. I took it out.

Unknown number.

I almost ignored it. But I answered.

A woman's voice. Calm. Flat.

"I know why you didn't tell them. But you can't keep this to yourself."

I asked who she was.

She said, "The person you saw. I know their name."

Then the line went dead.

Chapter Two

The Keeper

"It was mine to hide, so I buried it."

They keep asking me why I didn't come forward sooner.

I don't tell them the truth. I tell them I didn't know anything. That I didn't see enough. That it's all just noise and rumors.

But I know exactly what happened. I know because I was there before it happened. And I stayed after.

The thing I'm holding isn't a memory. It's physical. It's in my apartment, inside a box, inside a drawer I haven't opened in weeks.

Sometimes I hear it. Not like it's making noise, but like it's reminding me it's there.

The night it happened, I told myself I was helping. I told myself I was keeping it safe.

The truth is I didn't want anyone else to have it. Not the police. Not the people on the street. Not the news.

It's not money. It's not a weapon. It's worse than either of those.

I thought about throwing it in the river. But things like this have a way of coming back. You throw it away, and someone finds it. You give it to the wrong person, and it disappears until you see it again when it's too late.

So I kept it.

Now it's the only thing standing between me and what they think happened.

And sooner or later, someone is going to figure out I have it.

I didn't plan to talk to them. I was supposed to watch from a distance, make sure they weren't going to ruin everything.

But they made it too easy. Same route every day, same café at the corner, always with the same seat near the window.

I walked in like I was meeting someone else. No eye contact. I ordered coffee I didn't want and sat at the table behind them. Close enough to hear.

They were looking out the window, not at the street but at their own reflection. That's when I knew they were scared.

I leaned forward and said, "You didn't tell them."

They didn't turn around right away. They just froze, like they were deciding whether to run or pretend I wasn't talking to them.

When they finally looked at me, their face gave everything away. Confusion, fear and something else, the kind of curiosity that can get someone in trouble.

"I know who you saw," I said.

They didn't answer.

"You don't have to say anything here," I told them. "But if you want to survive this, you need to hear me out."

They glanced toward the door. I knew what they were thinking. If they walked out, maybe this would go away. But it wouldn't.

I slid a folded piece of paper onto their table.

"Read it when you're alone," I said. "Then decide if you want to stay alive."

I stood up and left.

From the window, I saw them pick up the paper before I even reached the corner.

After I left the café, I walked three blocks without looking back. I didn't need to. I knew they would read the paper.

The address on it wasn't mine. I've never been stupid enough to use mine. It's a storage unit on the edge of town. I've had it for years under another name. No cameras. No records worth finding.

That's where the box is. The thing I've been keeping.

The first time I opened it after that night, I only lasted a few seconds before I closed it again. I couldn't look too long. Not because I was scared of it. Because I knew once I started thinking about what it meant, I wouldn't be able to stop.

I thought about moving it. Somewhere safer. Somewhere no one would ever think to look. But moving it means carrying it, and carrying it means someone could see me with it.

So it stays.

At night, I keep the phone on silent. I don't answer unknown numbers. Still, I get messages. No names. No explanations. Just short sentences.

You're not the only one who knows.

We saw you leave with it.

If you want to keep it, talk to us first.

I delete them, but they keep coming.

Once, I found an envelope taped to my door. Inside was a photograph. Grainy, black and white. It showed me from behind, walking away from the scene that night.

I burned that one too. But burning things doesn't erase them.

Sometimes I wonder if the person in that café will help me keep it quiet or be the one to open the box for everyone to see.

I'm not ready to find out.

That night, I couldn't stop thinking about the box.

By midnight, I was in my car. The streets were empty. No headlights behind me, no one on the sidewalks. I kept checking the mirrors anyway.

The storage unit is in a row of twenty identical doors. The kind of place no one notices unless they have a reason to be there. My hands shook a little when I unlocked it.

The smell inside was the same. Old wood, dust, and something faintly metallic. I walked to the back where the box was, sitting exactly where I left it.

But the lid was tilted. Just enough to see it had been opened.

I didn't touch it. I didn't look inside. I just stood there, listening.

Somewhere outside, a car engine started. Then it faded away.

I pushed the lid back down and stepped away like it might explode if I got too close.

On the drive home, I kept the radio off. The sound of the tires was the only thing I heard.

When I got to my building, there was another envelope under my door.

This one didn't have a note.

Just a small, silver key.

Chapter Three

The Accuser

"I swore I'd bring it out."

People think the truth comes out on its own.

It doesn't.

You have to drag it out. You have to dig your hands in, even when it cuts you.

I've been following this case since day one. Not because I care about the victim. I didn't know them. But I knew what was going to happen if I didn't get involved.

The wrong person would take the fall, the right people would walk free, and the rest of the city would move on like it never happened. I've seen it too many times.

I keep a wall in my apartment covered in photographs, maps, and names. Not for decoration. For strategy. There are red circles, notes written in thick black marker, and strings running from one face to another. I know exactly who was there that night.

Two of them are still keeping quiet. One of them, the witness, is already shaking. The other, the one I call the keeper, is holding something back. Something physical. I don't know what it is yet, but I will.

I've sent messages. Left photographs. Made it clear they're not invisible. But I can't push too hard, not yet. If they bolt, I lose them.

So I wait. I watch the cafés, the bus stops, the markets. I watch the doorways when they walk past. I watch the windows above the street.

The night before last, I saw the keeper leave the storage unit. They didn't see me. I stayed in my car, lights off, two blocks away. I don't know what they were doing inside, but I know they weren't in there long.

Whatever is in that box, it's important enough for them to check on it in the middle of the night.

And if it's important to them, it's the one thing I need to see.

I'm not waiting for the truth to come out anymore.

I'm going to take it.

The first step was simple. I needed to know if the keeper ever came there during the day. Most people with something to hide go at night, thinking it's safer. But daylight has its advantages. People are in a rush. No one notices much.

I parked two streets away from the storage units and sat with a newspaper in my lap. I wasn't reading. I was watching the corner of the block. Anyone going in had to walk past the same cracked blue dumpster and the same graffiti-covered wall.

Two hours went by. No sign.

Then I saw someone else. Not the keeper. A man in a grey hoodie. He had keys. He moved like he knew where he was going. He didn't look around before unlocking a door three units down from the keeper's.

I made a note of the number. I don't believe in coincidences.

When he left, I checked the area. No cameras. No guard. Just a single old man who ran the desk inside the main office. I walked in, said I was interested in a unit, asked about prices.

While he was talking, I scanned the board behind him. It listed all the unit numbers and the dates they were last accessed. The keeper's unit had been opened at 12:46 a.m. that morning.

I thanked him, left, and went around to the back fence. It was high, but the wire at the top was loose. Someone had already bent it down.

I didn't go in. Not yet. I needed the right moment.

That moment came the next night.

I waited until just after midnight. The keeper's light was on at home. They weren't moving around much. Probably watching TV.

I drove back to the units, parked far enough away to walk in. The fence was the same. Loose wire, easy to pull down.

I kept my hands in gloves. No flashlight. I counted the doors until I reached theirs.

The lock was standard. A decent shove with the right tool would break it, but that would be loud. I used a pick set instead. Took less than a minute.

Inside, the air was stale. I could make out shapes — boxes, a chair, an old bike. And then I saw it.

The box.

It was heavier than I expected. I didn't open it there. I wanted a clean look under better light.

I carried it out, climbed back over the fence, and walked to my car.

On the drive home, I kept checking the mirrors. Nothing behind me.

At my apartment, I set the box on the table. I stood there for a long time before lifting the lid.

When I saw what was inside, I understood why the keeper had been so careful.

It wasn't just evidence.

It was the kind of thing people kill for.

I didn't sleep that night. The box sat on the table while I sat in the chair across from it. I didn't touch it again. I just kept looking at what was inside, trying to figure out the safest way to use it.

By morning, I had three options. Keep it hidden. Hand it over to the police. Or trade it for something I needed more.

Keeping it was risky. Handing it over meant losing control. Trading it... that was dangerous in a different way. But dangerous can work if you're the one holding the stronger hand.

Before the sun was up, I wrapped the contents in a thick plastic sheet and put them back in the box. I carried it to my car, drove two towns over, and rented a different storage unit under another name. This one had cameras. I wanted anyone who came for it to be seen.

When I left, I took the long way home. Stopped at a gas station for coffee. That's when I noticed the same grey sedan in the side mirror. Same dent in the front fender I'd seen near the units last night.

I pulled out slowly, turned down three side streets, and parked behind a delivery truck. The sedan passed without slowing.

Maybe it wasn't for me. Or maybe they just wanted me to know they were there.

Either way, the box isn't where the keeper left it anymore. And I'm the only one who knows where it is now.

For now.

Chapter Four

The Denier

"If I don't admit it, it never happened."

I've heard my name in connection with that night more than once. I don't react. I don't ask questions. I let people talk until they run out of things to say.

Most of them don't know anything. They're just repeating what they heard from someone else. That's how stories get made, not by the people who were there, but by the people who weren't.

I've made it simple for myself. If I never confirm anything, there's nothing to use against me.

I know about the box. I've known since the night it disappeared from the first place it was kept. I don't need to see it to know what's inside.

The mistake people make is thinking I'm afraid of it. I'm not. The real danger isn't the box. It's the people moving it around. Every time it changes hands, someone new gets involved, and that means someone new might talk.

Yesterday, I got a message from a number I didn't recognize. No words, just a picture. It was blurry, but I could tell it was the box. Different background this time. Not the storage unit I've seen before.

I deleted the message, but I didn't block the number. Whoever sent it wants me to know they have it. Blocking them means I lose the line to find out who.

I haven't told anyone I got that picture. Not the people asking me questions. Not the people watching me. The less I say, the more I control.

Still, I've changed my routine. I don't go straight home anymore. I take different routes. I sit in different places. I leave my phone in the kitchen at night and turn it off completely.

This morning, I noticed a car outside my building. It's been there twice this week. Same dent on the front fender. Same grey sedan.

I don't believe in coincidences. But I'm not going to confirm it's following me. If I admit that, I admit there's something worth following me for.

And right now, my only job is to act like none of this is happening.

Two days later, I went to the market near the bus station. I don't go there often, but it's crowded enough to make me harder to follow. Or at least that's the idea.

I was looking at a stack of apples when someone stopped beside me. I knew it wasn't an accident. People in a hurry don't stand still that long.

"You're making this worse for yourself," they said.

I didn't look at them. I kept checking the fruit like I was deciding which one to buy.

"I don't know what you're talking about," I said.

They gave a short laugh, no humor in it. "You've seen the picture. You know what's inside. You could make this a lot easier."

I put one apple in my bag and turned to face them. Average height, heavy jacket, sunglasses. The voice was familiar, but I couldn't place it.

"I think you have me confused with someone else," I told them.

"You can keep saying that," they said, leaning in slightly, "but it's not going to change what's coming."

I stepped past them and walked toward the bread counter. They didn't follow at first. I thought maybe that was it. But when I got to the register, they were there again, two people ahead of me in line.

They didn't speak this time. Just stood there, looking at nothing, waiting for me to notice they hadn't left.

When I paid and walked out, they stayed behind. I checked the street. The grey sedan was parked across from the exit.

I walked in the opposite direction, turned a corner, and went into a small electronics store. I stood between the shelves of phone cases for ten minutes.

When I came back out, the car was gone.

I don't know if that means I lost them or if they just wanted me to think I had.

Either way, I'm not changing what I'm doing. If I act like this is real, it becomes real.

And I'm not giving anyone that.

That night, I sat in the kitchen with the lights off. The window over the sink looks out onto the street. If you stand far enough back, no one outside can see you, but you can see them.

Just after midnight, the grey sedan rolled by. It didn't slow down. It didn't stop. But the passenger window was down, and someone inside held their phone up like they were recording.

They didn't need to say anything. That was the message.

I stayed at the window until the street was empty again. No more cars. No movement.

When I finally went to bed, I left my shoes by the door and my bag on the chair next to them. In the morning, the bag was still there, but the zipper was half open.

Nothing was missing. Not that I could tell. But someone had been close enough to touch my things without me knowing.

I locked the door behind me when I left for work, but it didn't feel like it mattered anymore.

Some things are already too far gone to lock out.

Chapter Five

The Stranger

"It wasn't my business, but it stayed in my mind."

I didn't know the person who died. I didn't know the people who were there that night either. I was just passing through.

It was late, and I was walking home from work. I usually take the main road, but that night I cut through a side street to save time.

That's when I saw them. Two people standing near the curb. One of them had their back to me, the other was facing the wall. I didn't think much of it until I heard a short, sharp sound.

I didn't stop. I didn't ask what happened. I kept walking until I was far enough away that I couldn't hear them anymore.

The next day, it was on the news. They didn't show much, just a sheet on the ground and some tape around the area. But I recognized the street. I recognized the way the camera panned across the buildings.

I told myself not to get involved. It wasn't my problem. I had nothing to do with it.

But a week later, I saw one of the people again. Same jacket. Same way of walking. This time they were coming out of a café with someone I didn't recognize. They didn't see me, but I saw them pass something across the table before they left.

That's when I started paying more attention. I'd spot them now and then. At the market. On the bus. Always looking around like they were checking for someone.

One night, I was sitting in my car outside my apartment building when I saw the grey sedan. It drove past slow, then circled the block.

I thought maybe I was imagining things. Then it parked at the corner, and someone got out. They stood there under the streetlight for a few minutes, then walked away.

Two days later, an envelope showed up in my mailbox. No name. No return address.

Inside was a picture of me walking down that side street the night it happened.

I didn't tell anyone. I didn't throw it away. I put it in a drawer and closed it.

But I know it's only a matter of time before someone asks me about it.

Three nights after I found the picture, someone knocked on my door. It was late, close to midnight. I don't usually answer at that hour, but I looked through the peephole.

A woman was standing there. Short hair. Heavy jacket. She wasn't looking at the door. She was looking down the hallway like she was making sure no one else was around.

I didn't open it.

She said, "I know you were there."

Her voice was calm, like she wasn't asking a question.

I stayed quiet.

She shifted her weight, looked straight at the peephole. "I'm not here to cause trouble. I just need to know what you saw."

I told her I didn't see anything.

She smiled a little, like she'd heard that before. "That's fine. We can pretend that's true. But sooner or later, someone else will ask you, and they won't be as polite."

I asked who she was.

She didn't answer. She reached into her pocket, pulled out an envelope, and slid it under the door. "Keep this safe. Don't open it here."

Then she walked away. No rush. No looking back.

I waited until I couldn't hear her footsteps before I picked it up. The envelope was thick. Inside was a smaller folded piece of paper and something hard, like a card or a key.

I didn't open it right away. I locked the door, turned off the lights, and went into the bedroom.

When I finally looked, it was a photograph. This time, it wasn't of me. It was of a storage unit door, half open.

The piece of paper had a single sentence: **You'll need this before they find you.**

The hard object was a small silver key.

I put it all back in the envelope and shoved it into the back of my closet. I didn't sleep much after that. Every sound in the hallway made me look at the door.

The next morning, I saw the grey sedan parked across the street from my building.

It stayed there until I left for work.

That night, I kept the envelope on the table while I made dinner. I didn't open it again, but I kept glancing at it like it might move on its own.

Around nine, I heard voices outside. Not loud enough to make out words, but enough to know there were at least two people. I went to the window and pulled the curtain just enough to see.

The grey sedan was there again. Same dent in the front fender. This time, the passenger door was open and someone was leaning against it, talking to another person on the sidewalk.

The one on the sidewalk was the woman from my door.

She looked up toward my building. I let the curtain fall back before she could see me.

A few minutes later, I heard footsteps in the hallway. Slow. Unhurried. They stopped outside my door. No knock this time. Just silence.

Then the sound of paper sliding on the floor.

When I looked down, there was another envelope. No writing on it.

Inside was a single line on a piece of plain white paper:

Don't wait until they come in.

I locked every lock on the door that night.

Chapter Six

The Investigator

"Truth isn't found. It's forced out."

Cases like this don't work themselves out. People don't suddenly start telling the truth because they feel guilty. You push, they resist. You push harder, they slip. That's when you get what you need.

I wasn't assigned to this officially. I've been on the outside from the start. No badge. No reports to file. That's an advantage. It means I can go places and ask questions without a trail.

I started with the location. That street isn't random. It's a good cut-through if you're avoiding main roads. Cameras are scarce. Lighting is bad. I walked it twice, once in daylight, once after dark.

I spoke to the man who runs the corner store. He remembered the night clearly. Said business was slow until he heard a sound outside. Sharp, quick. Not loud enough to be a gunshot, but enough to make him step to the window. By the time he looked, there was already a small crowd.

He didn't see faces. Not clearly. But he noticed one person walking away faster than the rest. Brown coat. Dark bag. I've already seen that in stills from the scene. Matches the witness.

I've been tracking the witness since then. They've been avoiding the main streets, keeping their head down. That usually means they know more than they're saying.

Then there's the keeper. Harder to follow. Careful. Changes routes. Checks reflections in shop windows. But I know about the storage unit, and I know it's not the only one they've used.

Two nights ago, I saw someone else leaving that same row of units. Not the keeper. The accuser, though I didn't have a name for them yet. They were carrying something heavy. They loaded it into their car and left without looking back.

I didn't follow them that night. I wanted to see what happened next. Yesterday, the grey sedan showed up outside the denier's building. Same car I've spotted near the stranger's place.

That means one thing. Someone's connecting the pieces too, and they're not doing it quietly.

If I'm going to get to the truth first, I'll need to move faster.

I decided to start with the witness. They're the easiest to rattle.

I waited near the café they always use. Corner table, same time almost every day. People think routines make them feel safe. They don't realize it makes them predictable.

They came in at ten past eleven. Same coat, same bag. Ordered coffee and sat down without looking around. I took the seat across from them before they could react.

They froze for a second, then tried to cover it with a nervous smile.

"You've been avoiding a lot of questions," I said.

"I don't know what you're talking about," they replied.

"That's fine. I'm not here to get you in trouble. I'm here to make sure you don't end up in it."

They looked at the door, then back at me. "I already told the police what I saw."

"No," I said, leaning forward, "you told them what you wanted them to hear. There's a difference."

They didn't answer.

I pulled a photograph from my jacket pocket and set it on the table. It showed the storage unit door half open. No one in the frame, just the door and the shadow on the floor inside.

Their eyes stayed on the photo longer than they wanted to.

"You've seen this before," I said.

They shook their head, but it was too late. Their reaction told me more than their words.

I took the photo back, slid it into my pocket, and stood up.

"If you decide you want to stay ahead of what's coming, you'll find me."

I left them sitting there, staring at the empty table.

Outside, I crossed the street and leaned against a lamppost. Through the window, I saw them pull out their phone and start typing.

I don't know who they were messaging. But whoever it was, they're part of this now too.

I didn't go far after leaving the café. I walked three blocks and stopped at a bench where I could see both ends of the street. Ten minutes later, the grey sedan rolled past. Slow. Checking both sidewalks.

They didn't notice me. Their focus was on the café. They parked half a block away and stayed inside the car.

The witness came out a few minutes later. Instead of going home, they walked in the opposite direction. The sedan waited until they were two streets down before pulling out and following.

I didn't follow either of them. I went for the bigger target. The storage units.

By the time I got there, it was just after noon. I walked in and signed the visitor log like I was looking for a unit to rent. The clerk didn't care. While they talked about monthly rates, I kept my eyes on the board behind them. Unit numbers and dates.

The keeper's unit hadn't been opened in over a week. But another unit I recognized from earlier, the one the accuser had visited had been accessed twice in the last three days.

I left the office and walked the row until I found it. The lock looked new. No scratches. No sign of tampering.

I didn't touch it. I just memorized the details. The number. The type of lock. The small rust mark near the bottom corner of the door.

On the way out, I noticed a small camera mounted on the far wall, pointing toward the row. It wasn't there last time.

Someone else is watching now.

I don't know if they're looking for the same thing I am, but it means one thing, time is running out to get to that box before the wrong hands close around it.

Chapter Seven

The Broken One

"When it came out, it took me with it."

I used to think I could handle anything. I've been through worse than this. Or at least I thought I had.

It's not the kind of thing that hits you all at once. At first, you think you're fine. You tell yourself you can keep going like normal. Then little things start to slip. You forget where you put your keys. You burn your food because you can't stop staring at the wall. You wake up at three in the morning and can't remember if you locked the door.

That's where I've been living. In that space where nothing feels solid anymore.

Since that night, it's like every part of my life is under a light. I can feel people looking at me differently. Some of them know why. Most of them don't. It doesn't matter. Once you're marked in their minds, you can't undo it.

I hear the same car outside almost every night now. Slow, steady, never stopping for long. I don't need to look out the window to know what it is.

Two weeks ago, I got a phone call in the middle of the night. No one said anything. Just breathing. I hung up after a minute. Five minutes later, it rang again. Same thing. I didn't answer the third time.

Last Tuesday, I opened my mailbox and found a small brown envelope. Inside was a photo of me from behind, walking into my building. The angle was low, like someone was crouched down when they took it. There was no note, no explanation.

I haven't shown it to anyone. If I do, I have to answer questions I'm not ready for.

The thing is, I didn't even have a choice in all this. I didn't ask to be involved. I didn't go looking for it. But somehow I ended up holding a piece of it, and once you're holding something like that, there's no way to put it down without it cutting you.

I've thought about leaving the city. Just disappearing. But that only works if no one knows where you're going. And with the way they're watching me, I'm not sure that's possible anymore.

Last night, I heard footsteps in the hallway outside my door. They stopped right in front of it. No knock. No sound after that. Just silence.

I stood on the other side, holding my breath, waiting. Then I heard the faint scrape of paper on the floor.

When I opened the door, there was a single sheet. No envelope this time. Just one sentence in black ink:

It's your turn to talk.

I stood there for a long time with that paper in my hand. The words weren't a threat, not directly. But they were a push. Someone was done waiting for me to come forward.

I put the paper on the kitchen table and stared at it while the coffee brewed. It was still there when the cup was empty. Still there two hours later.

By noon, I'd convinced myself to throw it away. I even walked it to the trash chute in the hallway. But I didn't drop it. I folded it back up and slid it into my jacket pocket.

That night, I went to the payphone near the train station. I haven't used it in years, but I know it still works. I dialed the number that's been calling me from blocked IDs. I've memorized it by now.

Someone picked up on the second ring. No hello. Just breathing.

"You wanted me to talk," I said.

The breathing stopped. A man's voice this time. "Tomorrow. Same payphone. Eight p.m."

Then the line went dead.

I hung up and walked away, checking the street behind me every few steps. No one followed. At least no one I could see.

Back in my apartment, I put the paper in a drawer and locked it. I don't know if I'm going to show up tomorrow. But I also know I'm not going to be able to stop thinking about it until I do.

I didn't sleep much that night. Every time I closed my eyes, I imagined the payphone in the dark, the metal receiver swinging back and forth, no one on the other end.

In the morning, I tried to focus on work. I kept my head down, avoided small talk, but it didn't help. Every sound made me turn my head.

By late afternoon, I'd made up my mind. I was going.

I got there early. The street was quiet, most of the shops already closed. The payphone stood at the corner, the glass scratched and fogged with fingerprints.

I waited, leaning against the wall, pretending to check my watch. At exactly eight, the phone rang.

I picked it up.

"Turn around," the voice said.

I turned. Across the street, under the light of a flickering sign, a man was watching me. He wasn't holding a phone. He just stood there with his hands in his pockets.

"You have something," he said. "Or you know who does."

I didn't answer.

He stepped off the curb, started walking toward me. Halfway across, a car came down the street, forcing him to stop.

When it passed, he was gone.

I hung up the phone and scanned the street, but there was no one.

That's when I realized there was something in the coin return. I reached in and pulled out a small folded piece of paper.

It had only two words: **Too late.**

Chapter Eight

The Reckoner

"We all paid for what we hid."

I've been watching them for weeks now. The witness, the keeper, the accuser, the denier, the stranger, the broken one. They've all been moving like they still have control.

They don't.

The thing about keeping secrets is you start thinking they're still yours. But once other people know, they belong to everyone. And if they belong to everyone, someone's going to use them.

I've seen the box. I've touched it. I know exactly what's inside. I also know it's been moved at least twice in the last month. That's not by accident. That's because no one trusts anyone else.

I'm not here to find the truth. I already have it. I'm here to make sure every person who thought they could hide something gets what's coming.

Yesterday, I followed the grey sedan. It led me to the storage units on the edge of town. I didn't go in. I didn't need to. I saw who came out. The accuser, carrying nothing. Which means whatever they wanted is already gone.

Later that night, I stopped by the café where the witness spends most of their mornings. I didn't speak to them. I just sat in the back, long enough for them to notice I was there. Sometimes you don't need to say anything to get inside someone's head.

I've got records. Photos. Copies of messages. Timelines that show exactly where everyone was, even when they think no one was watching.

Some of them are already breaking. You can see it in how they move, how they talk. The broken one is the weakest. They're ready to give up, even if they don't admit it yet.

The keeper is still holding back, but they're nervous. Nervous people slip.

The stranger is scared, but they're not stupid. They know enough to keep quiet, but the more they're pushed, the more likely they are to talk.

The denier is the hardest. They think that staying silent is winning. But all it does is make the fall worse when it comes.

This isn't about who's guilty and who's not. This is about the fact that they all played a part. And now it's time they all understand what that means.

I've got a list of names, and by the time I'm done, every one of them will wish they'd said more, sooner.

I started early. Before the streets filled and before anyone could decide to disappear.

The first stop was the witness. I didn't knock. I slid a plain envelope under their door. Inside was a single photograph of them from that Thursday afternoon, head turned toward the scene. No words, no threats. Just proof that I knew exactly what they saw.

The second stop was the keeper. I left a small silver key in their mailbox. Not the one to their storage unit. A different one. One they would have to figure out. By the time they did, the storage unit they've been guarding would already be empty.

The accuser was next. For them, I didn't leave anything physical. Just a call from a number that couldn't be traced, with thirty seconds of silence before I hung up. That would be enough to make them wonder how close I'd been.

The denier got a different approach. I walked into the market they visit every week and stood in the next aisle over, making sure they could hear my voice as I asked the clerk about security cameras. I never looked at them, but I know they knew it was me.

For the stranger, I mailed a copy of the photograph they had in their closet, the one they thought no one else had seen. I added the time and date in red ink. They'd know I wasn't guessing.

The broken one didn't get a warning. They got a visit. I didn't stay long, and I didn't need to speak. I put a single sheet of paper on their table and walked out. It said only this: *It's done.*

By noon, every piece was in place. By evening, none of them could pretend they were outside of it anymore.

That night, the story broke. The picture of the box was on every screen. The news didn't say where it came from. They didn't need to. Anyone who had been close to it would know exactly what they were looking at.

Some of them would run. Some would try to explain. Some would deny they were ever involved.

It didn't matter.

Because the thing about truth is, once it's out, it doesn't belong to you anymore.

It belongs to everyone who sees it. Everyone who talks about it. Everyone who passes it on until the whole story is out of your hands.

I didn't need to watch the rest of the coverage. I already knew how it would end.

It ends the same way for all of them.

They live with it.

Epigraph

Two weeks later, the story was gone from the front pages.
No more interviews. No more late-night updates. The headlines had moved on to
something else.

But not everyone had.

The witness had moved out. No forwarding address.
The keeper's unit was still empty, lock hanging loose.
The accuser stopped talking to the reporter halfway through the interview and walked
out.

The denier still kept the same routine, but now there was always someone new in the
market when they shopped.

The stranger's apartment blinds stayed closed all day.
The broken one hadn't been seen in days.

The box never turned up. At least not officially.

One night, a small, grainy clip appeared on an anonymous forum. Just six seconds long.
A table. A pair of gloved hands.
The lid of the box being lifted.

The video cut off before anyone could see what was inside.

The comments were full of guesses.
No one agreed on the truth.

And that was the only thing that never changed.

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About the Author

Sonia Benjoye is the author of multiple works of fiction and nonfiction, known for writing intense, character-driven stories that dig into human behavior and the choices people make under pressure.

Her books span a range of themes, from personal survival and relationships to power, truth, and the consequences of secrets. Sonia's work is built on sharp observation, grounded storytelling, and an unflinching approach to human complexity.

She continues to write and publish independently, connecting directly with her readers and building a body of work that challenges, engages, and lingers long after the last page.

Also by **Sonia Benjoye**

- *What It Took*
- *The Paradox of Passion*
- *Woman. Weapon. Work.*
- *This Is the Season for Guts*
- *God Was Never the Problem*
- *Mother. Monster. Machine.*
- *Black Veins, Open Mouth*
- *Her Hand Held the Future, Her Back Held the Weight*
- *The Beautiful Discipline of Boredom*
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